PRODUCT LEADERSHIP CERTIFICATE · FINAL PROJECT

The Second Journey

Retaining Fable Users Beyond Recovery

We retain users after their acute need is resolved, by building confidence, proactive action, and successful re-engagement.

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THE CASE

Five deliverables, one strategy

Each lab committed one decision. Together they are the bet, the sequence, the team that owns it, the money, and what I learned building it.

- **1. Product Strategy,** the bet: win the post-acute moment with trusted wellness memory, and refuse engagement mechanics to get there.
- **2. Outcome Roadmap,** the sequence: fix the moments first (Rock #1), then the big personalization bet (Rock #2), then onboarding (Rock #3).
- **3. Team Charter,** the team that owns it: three PMs, one mission, decision rules written before the disagreements arrive.
- **4. Financial Model,** the money: LTV $118 to $171 at an unchanged $54 CAC, with kill criteria committed before launch.
- **5. Individual Insights,** what I learned: churn here is a success problem, and a charter is an operating tool, not paperwork.

MODULE 1 · PRODUCT STRATEGY

Playing to Win: the post-acute moment is the market

THE CASCADE

- **Winning aspiration,** users feel stronger, more self-aware, and more capable, whether they open Fable daily or only when it matters most.
- **Where to play,** digitally comfortable adults, in established markets, who have emerged from an acute episode of anxiety or stress and want to protect their progress.
- **How to win,** become the most trusted source of personal wellness knowledge in a user's life. Features can be copied; a longitudinal, trusted wellness memory cannot.
- **Capabilities,** build wellness intelligence, trusted AI guidance, behavioral science, privacy, outcomes measurement. Partner for clinical; buy commodity infrastructure.

THE ONE HARD NO

Fable will not optimize for engagement, even when doing so would accelerate growth.

Engagement mechanics create dependence. This strategy only works if users grow more resilient, including when they open Fable less.

OKR CASCADE

Objective: Enable users to sustain well-being after the acute phase, building confidence, self-awareness, and resilience without increasing dependence on Fable.

- **KR1 Confidence:** 42% to 65% ·
- **KR2 Proactive action:** 25% to 50% ·
- **KR3 Successful re-engagement:** 30% to 55%

MODULE 2 · OUTCOME ROADMAP

Bets sequenced by outcome, not by feature

NOW · 0-3 MO

- **Support at the right moment**, re-engagement, KR3 30% to 55% (PM2)
- **Guidance grounded in personal history**, confidence + proactive action, KR1/KR2 (PM3)
- **Value beyond acute recovery**, long-term return behavior, KR3 (PM2)

NEXT · 3-6 MO

- **Smoother acute, resilience transition**, long-term retention (PM2)
- **Earlier pattern detection**, intervene before users are overwhelmed, KR2 (PM3)
- **Lightweight companion experiences**, re-engagement without dependency, KR3 (PM2)

LATER · 6-12 MO

- **Professional support at the right moments**, via partners, for needs beyond self-guided (PM3)
- **Wearable signals**, earlier recognition of well-being changes (PM3)
- **International expansion**, only once the retention model is proven in core markets (PM2)

TRADE-OFFS WE DEFENDED

- **Sequenced first:** fix notifications (Rock #1), AI check-in prompts personalized to user history (Rock #2, the big bet), onboarding redesign on the 40% drop-off data (Rock #3).
- **Cut entirely:** daily streaks (engagement, not resilience) · content library (a crowded market that doesn't test our hypothesis) · Fable for Teams (a new buyer and business model before the core model is proven).

MODULE 3 · TEAM CHARTER

What we own, and how we decide

Mission: We retain users after their acute need is resolved by building confidence (KR1), proactive action (KR2), and successful re-engagement (KR3).

WHAT WE OWN

- **Post-Acute Retention Strategy**, roadmap and OKRs for KR1-KR3
- **PM1 · Onboarding**, activation and the onboarding experience
- **PM2 · Retention**, re-engagement journeys and notification strategy
- **PM3 · AI Check-ins**, personalization engine and wellness memory

OUT OF SCOPE, BY DESIGN

- **Engagement-first growth**, DAU, streaks, session frequency, pressure loops
- **Content platform bets** and clinical care delivery
- **B2B / employer products** and new-market expansion untested by the retention model
- **Platform expansion for its own sake**, web, wearables, integrations without KR evidence

HOW WE DECIDE

- **Default:** PMs decide collaboratively or defer to the correct PM; unresolved calls escalate to the Core Product Lead, decision within 3 business days (1 week if quarterly commitments are affected).
- **Joint calls:** anything touching wellness memory, user data, or personalization rules, all three PMs, with Privacy and Legal. Safety, legal, and regulatory requirements are non-negotiable.

MODULE 5 · FINANCIAL MODEL

The bet: monetize the asset only Fable has

Generic wellness advice is free from every competitor. The alternatives don't fix the leak, acquisition pours users into the same bucket at $54 a head, and human coaching personalizes but can't scale. Rock #2 (personalized support using wellness memory) raises the value of users we already paid to acquire.

CAC	LTV	Investment	Expected return	Payback	Return multiple
$54, unchanged	**$118 to $171 (+45%)**	**$210K, one quarter of the pod**	**~$690K incremental annual revenue**	**Within ~2 quarters**	**~3.3× first-year**

Modeled assumptions, flagged as such: ~52,000 users/year complete an acute episode; a 25-point re-engagement lift ≈ 13,000 additional retained users × $53 LTV lift. AI inference ≈ $0.90 per active user/month.

KILL CRITERIA, WRITTEN BEFORE LAUNCH, NOT NEGOTIATED AFTER

- **KR1 below 52% by June 30, 2027:** stop personalization development; revert to the standard check-in cadence.
- **KR2 below 35% by June 30, 2027:** kill AI-generated prompts; redirect the pod to Rock #1 (re-engagement timing).
- **KR3 up fewer than 5 points by September 30, 2027:** stop funding this rock; reallocate the pod to the next strategic bet.
- **Guardrail, overrides everything:** complaints or opt-outs above 2% in any month pause the AI prompts immediately.

MODULE 6 · INDIVIDUAL INSIGHTS

What I learned

FRICTION

The hardest part wasn't the strategy, it was turning "we collaborate" into decision rules that survive a real disagreement.

The mission one-liner was the last blank in the charter. I worked through it by forcing one row per decision, a named default rule, and clocks on every escalation.

The AI pressure test caught my KR3 measuring an output in disguise, it is now an outcome: successful re-engagement.

KEY LEARNING

A charter is an operating tool, not documentation.

I used to treat it as paperwork that follows the real decisions. This project reversed that: the charter's decision rules are the thing that makes every later decision faster.

Same discipline everywhere: kill criteria written with the business case, modeled numbers flagged as modeled, and AI used as the devil's advocate before the room does it for you.

THE AHA

Churn is a success problem, not a failure problem. Users don't leave Fable because it failed, they leave because it worked. The acute need ends, and so does the relationship. That one realization reorganized the entire strategy around the moment after success.